

“... THERE'S FLAMES, NOW, AND THE FRAME IS CRASHING TO THE GROUND... OH, THE HUMANITY...”

Herbert Robertson, Chicago news reporter, as he watched the *Hindenburg* crash, May 6, 1937

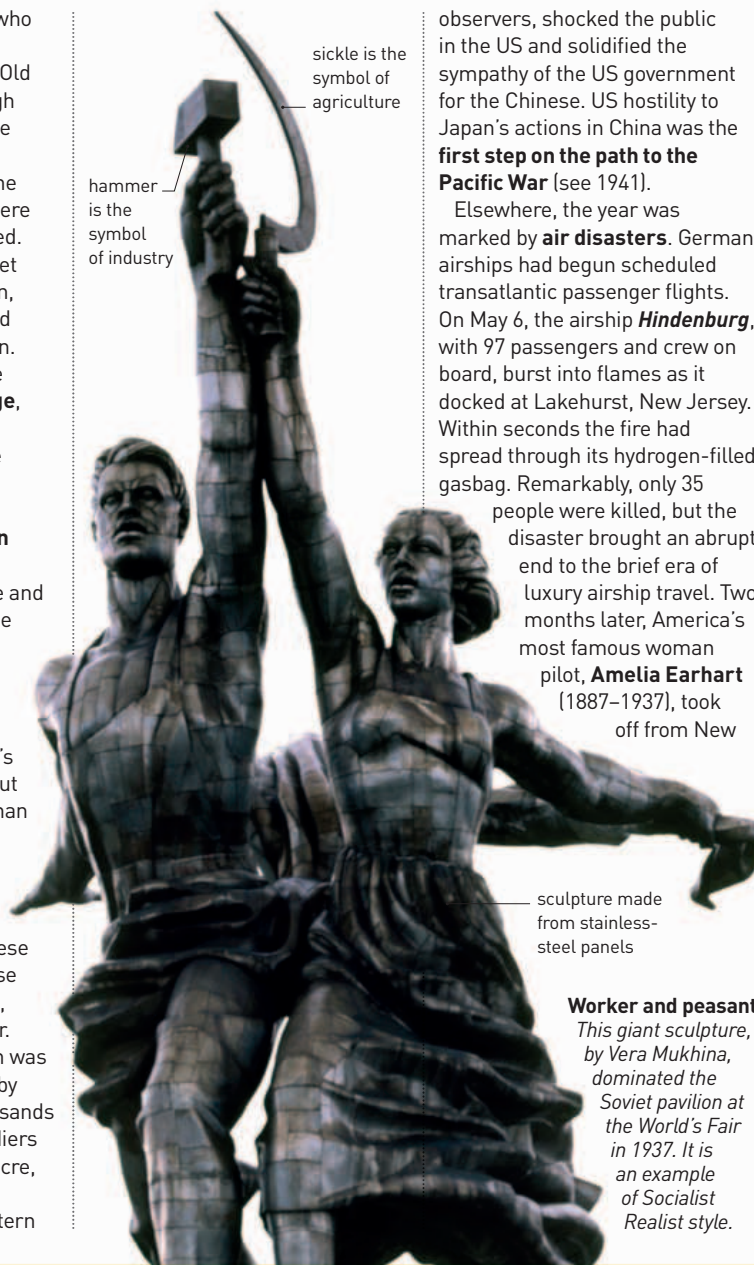
The German Zeppelin airship *Hindenburg* exploding into a fireball while docking at Lakehurst in New Jersey. The cause of the disaster remains uncertain.

paintings by modernists and Jews at a “**Degenerate Art**” exhibition in Munich, to be laughed at by the German public.

Meanwhile, under the dictatorship of Joseph Stalin (1878–1953), the Soviet Union had begun the **Great Terror**. The Soviet regime had always been ruthless toward those it defined as enemies—for example, peasants who resisted collective agriculture [see 1930]—but now the unbridled power of the secret police was turned against the leadership of the Soviet armed forces, and of the ruling party itself. The process began in 1936, with the arrest, trial, and execution

of “**Old Bolsheviks**”—men who had participated in the 1917 Revolution. While arrests of Old Bolsheviks continued through 1937, other people also came under suspicion. Between 1937 and 1939 almost half the senior army commanders were executed, imprisoned, or fired. Although the fate of the Soviet elite attracted most attention, Stalin’s reign of terror spread through the entire population. At least 680,000 people were killed during the **Great Purge**, and some historians believe the real figure could even be closer to 2 million.

In summer 1937, gradual **Japanese encroachment on Chinese territory** erupted into full-scale war. Japanese and Chinese forces clashed at the Marco Polo Bridge outside Beijing in July, and the following month large-scale fighting developed in Shanghai. **Chiang Kai-shek’s** Chinese Nationalist forces put up much stiffer resistance than the Japanese expected, inflicting around 50,000 casualties on the invaders, but they were forced to abandon the city. The Japanese then advanced on the Chinese Nationalist capital, **Nanking**, which they took in December. Nanking’s civilian population was subjected to a brutal attack by Japanese troops, while thousands of surrendered Chinese soldiers were also killed. This massacre, witnessed by Christian missionaries and other Western



hammer is the symbol of industry

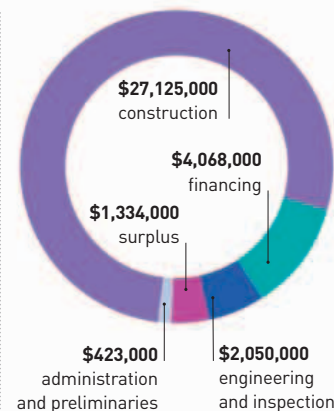
sickle is the symbol of agriculture

sculpture made from stainless-steel panels

Worker and peasant
This giant sculpture, by Vera Mukhina, dominated the Soviet pavilion at the World’s Fair in 1937. It is an example of Socialist Realist style.

observers, shocked the public in the US and solidified the sympathy of the US government for the Chinese. US hostility to Japan’s actions in China was the **first step on the path to the Pacific War** (see 1941).

Elsewhere, the year was marked by **air disasters**. German airships had begun scheduled transatlantic passenger flights. On May 6, the airship *Hindenburg*, with 97 passengers and crew on board, burst into flames as it docked at Lakehurst, New Jersey. Within seconds the fire had spread through its hydrogen-filled gasbag. Remarkably, only 35 people were killed, but the disaster brought an abrupt end to the brief era of luxury airship travel. Two months later, America’s most famous woman pilot, **Amelia Earhart** (1887–1937), took off from New



Golden Gate Bridge building costs
The original budget for building San Francisco’s Golden Gate Bridge was \$27 million, but the actual building costs totaled \$35 million.

Guinea with co-pilot Fred Noonan for the Pacific leg of an attempted **around-the-world flight**. Their aircraft was never seen again.

Technology continued to progress throughout the year, culminating in the race for the first successful **trials of turbojet engines**, between Frank Whittle in Britain and Hans von Ohain in Germany. Whittle won, but the Germans forged ahead with development of a jet aircraft—Ohain’s engine powering the first jet flight in August 1939.

Another marker for progress was the opening of the **Golden Gate Bridge** in San Francisco. At 4,200 ft (1,280 m), its central span was the longest of any suspension bridge in the world, a record that stood until it was surpassed by the Verrazano-Narrows Bridge in New York in 1964.

